

153 Gamaliel

The respected teacher who told the council to leave the apostles alone.

Gamaliel was a Pharisee and teacher of the law, honoured by all the people of Jerusalem. He appears only twice in the New Testament, but both times matter. When the council was ready to kill the apostles, Gamaliel gave calm advice. If this movement came from men, it would fall apart. If it came from God, no one could stop it, and they might be fighting against God. The council agreed, and the apostles were beaten but freed. Years later Paul said he had been trained "at the feet of Gamaliel." Scripture never says Gamaliel believed, but his caution gave the young church room to grow.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Gamliel</i> , "God is my reward"
Family	Not given; tradition makes him Hillel's grandson
Role	Pharisee, "a doctor of the law," member of the council (Acts 5:34)
When	Teaching in Jerusalem in the early first century AD
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	Peter and the apostles; the high priest; Paul, his former student
Main passages	Acts 5:17–42; 22:3
Not the same as	Gamaliel son of Pedahzur, a leader of Manasseh (Numbers 1:10)

"But if it be of God, ye cannot overthrow it; lest haply ye be found even to fight against God."

Acts 5:39, KJV

The life of Gamaliel

Dates are approximate (AD). Scripture gives no dates for Gamaliel. The council scene comes a few years after Pentecost, c. AD 30–33.

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| Before c. AD 30
<i>Jerusalem</i> | <p>● A respected teacher</p> <p>Gamaliel is a Pharisee and a doctor of the law, "had in reputation among all the people." He teaches in Jerusalem and sits on the council, the highest Jewish court. <i>Acts 5:34</i></p> |
| Before c. AD 30
<i>Jerusalem</i> | <p>● Trains Saul of Tarsus</p> <p>A young man from Tarsus in Cilicia studies under him. Saul is taught "according to the perfect manner of the law of the fathers" and becomes zealous for God. <i>Acts 22:3; 26:4–5</i></p> |
| c. AD 30–33
<i>Before the council</i> | <p>● The apostles on trial</p> <p>The high priest's party arrests the apostles for preaching in the temple. Peter answers, "We ought to obey God rather than men." The council is furious and wants to kill them. <i>Acts 5:17–33</i></p> |
| The same day | <p>● Gamaliel speaks</p> <p>He has the apostles put outside for a while. He reminds the council of Theudas and Judas of Galilee, whose movements died with them. He advises them to let these men alone. <i>Acts 5:34–39</i></p> |
| The same day | <p>● The council agrees</p> <p>The council takes his advice. The apostles are beaten, told not to speak in Jesus' name, and released. They leave rejoicing and keep preaching daily. <i>Acts 5:40–42</i></p> |
| c. AD 57
<i>Jerusalem</i> | <p>● Paul names his teacher</p> <p>Arrested in the temple, Paul speaks to the crowd in Hebrew. He tells them he was "brought up in this city at the feet of Gamaliel." <i>Acts 21:40–22:3</i></p> |

Key activities

Gamaliel mentions Theudas before Judas of Galilee (c. AD 6). The historian Josephus describes a Theudas who rebelled c. AD 44–46, after this speech. Many think Gamaliel meant an earlier Theudas, while others suspect a problem in the sources. The question is still discussed.

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- 1 Taught the law.** He was a doctor of the law, honoured by all the people. *Acts 5:34*
 - 2 Trained Paul.** Paul was brought up "at the feet of Gamaliel." *Acts 22:3*
 - 3 Slowed down an angry council.** He had the apostles put outside "a little space" so the council could think. *Acts 5:34–35*
 - 4 Pointed to history.** He showed that the movements of Theudas and Judas of Galilee came to nothing after their leaders died. *Acts 5:36–37*
 - 5 Warned against fighting God.** "If this counsel or this work be of men, it will come to nought: But if it be of God, ye cannot overthrow it." *Acts 5:38–39*
 - 6 Persuaded the council.** "And to him they agreed," and the apostles were released alive. *Acts 5:40*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Gamaliel.

Old Testament

Numbers 1:10; 7:54	A different Gamaliel, leader of Manasseh
Echo: Proverbs 19:21	"The counsel of the LORD, that shall stand"
Echo: Proverbs 21:30	No wisdom or counsel against the LORD

New Testament

Acts 5:34–40	His speech in the council
Acts 22:3	Paul trained at his feet
Philippians 3:5–6; Galatians 1:14	Paul's strict Pharisee training
Echo: John 7:50–51	Nicodemus asks the council for a fair hearing
Tradition	Jewish tradition: a leading rabbi of Hillel's school. Christian legend, not Scripture: later baptized

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What two possibilities did Gamaliel lay before the council (Acts 5:38–39)?
2. *Understand:* Scripture never says Gamaliel followed Jesus. How is being open-minded different from trusting Christ?
3. *Apply:* Gamaliel calmed an angry room. When a conversation heats up this week, how can you slow it down?
4. *Apply:* Is there any place where you might be resisting something God is doing?